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T. S. Eliot and Yves Congar on the Nature of Tradition

T. S. Eliot's status as the great poet-critic of this century is « generally acknowledged » ⁽¹⁾. In 1920, he published an article entitled « Tradition and the Individual Talent » which amply repays theologically-informed attention ⁽²⁾. In this article, Eliot argued that poetic talent, literary creativity and critical energies were all being misused and misdirected in the literary writing of the time. The reading public looks for originality, novelty, personality in authors. It insists upon those aspects of a writer's work in which he or she least resembles anyone else. Whereas, Eliot asserted, the truest originality of a poet may lie in those parts of his work in which « the dead poets, his ancestors, assert their immortality most vigorously » ⁽³⁾. This, he went on, was not at all a question of blind or timid adherence to the generation immediately prior to one's own. The relationship involved encloses, rather, the entire past of the literary tradition. The sphere of life in which the poet and critic should live is this past tradition in its presence: the total past as now. The historical sense

compels a man to write not merely with his own generation in his bones, but with a feeling that the whole of the literature of Europe from Homer and within it the whole of the literature of his country has a simultaneous existence and composes a simultaneous order ⁽⁴⁾.

⁽¹⁾ E. LOBB, *T. S. Eliot and the Romantic Critical Tradition* (London 1981), p. 11.

⁽²⁾ T. S. ELIOT, « Tradition and the Individual Talent » in *The Sacred Wood: Essays on Poetry and Criticism* (London 1920).

⁽³⁾ *Ib.* p. 48.

⁽⁴⁾ *Ib.* p. 49.

Far from dulling one's sense of one's own time, it is precisely this situating of one generation within the totality of the whole that makes a writer most acutely aware of his contemporaneity, his particular and unique moment in time.

To ignore or devalue tradition is to enthrone the subjectivity of the poet in a pejorative sense of the word « subjectivity ». It is to enthrone the isolated self, a self dependent on its own posturings for making a mark in the world. This little self is thus thrown back on its own resources, without full access to the wider realm of meaning in which its experiences and utterances take on their proper status and value. Ideally, personality is transmuted into the aesthetic « world » of the literary work, a world which is, or can be, an evocation of the order of being itself. Such transmutation is, admittedly, a difficult process. When it fails, we become conscious of the speaker, rather than of the situation or reality about which he is trying to speak. As the « First Epigraph », ascribed to Heraclitus, in Eliot's poem *Burnt Norton* puts it:

Although there is but one Centre, most men live in centres of their own ⁽⁵⁾.

Whatever « most men » may do, however, there is a kind of immaturity, Eliot says, in having personal preferences where tradition is concerned. At least, one may have them, as one may have tastes in painting, but one should not make them decisive. The poet

can neither take the past as a lump, an indiscriminate *bolus*, nor can he form himself wholly on one or two private admirations; nor can he form himself wholly upon one preferred period. The first course is inadmissible, the second is an important experience of youth, and the third is a pleasant and highly desirable supplement ⁽⁶⁾.

Eliot anticipated a number of objections that might be

⁽⁵⁾ See G. SMITH, *T. S. Eliot's Poems and Plays: A Study in Sources and Meaning* (Chicago 1960), p. 255.

⁽⁶⁾ T. S. ELIOT, *The Sacred Wood*, *op. cit.*, p. 51.

loded against this account of tradition in the literary sphere. Firstly, it may be asked: Does it not demand an impossible erudition of every writer and reader? No, replied Eliot, he was not appealing for the replacement of creative writers by pedants. He was simply asking that the poet's awareness of the past should grow throughout his career. The writer must make « a continual surrender of himself as he is at the moment to something which is more valuable » ⁽⁷⁾. Secondly: Will not this lordship of tradition make the free personal spirit into a serf? Will it not, in other words, de-personalise author and critic alike? In answer to this, Eliot speaks with two voices. In one voice he agrees with the assertion but tries to turn its vice into virtue. De-personalising is exactly, he says, what he wants to attain, for

the poet has not a « personality » to express but a particular medium, which is only a medium and not a personality, in which impressions and experience combine in peculiar and unexpected ways ⁽⁸⁾.

I do not propose to endorse this remark for several reasons. To begin with, Eliot's own poetry and criticism make it clear that his sense of the individual was in fact alive and flourishing, in concert with his sense of tradition. As he wrote in an essay on the dramatist John Ford:

A man might, hypothetically, compose any number of fine passages or even of whole poems, which would each give satisfaction and yet not be a great poet unless we felt them to be united by one significant, consistent and developing personality ⁽⁹⁾.

A second reason for rejecting Eliot's language of de-personalisation here is that while Eliot lived in a « moment » of Western culture in which the cult of personality, excessive individualism, was a grave temptation, our culture today is faced not only

⁽⁷⁾ *Ib.*, p. 52.

⁽⁸⁾ *Ib.*, p. 56.

⁽⁹⁾ T. S. ELIOT, *Selected Essay* (London 1961³), p. 203.

with this temptation but also with its extreme opposite, the cult of structure, excessive anti-individualism. A generation which has witnessed the Structuralist attempt to reduce personhood to the intersecting of structures, and the personal voice to the « speaking of the structures », will see too many perils in Eliot's language at this point to want to make it their own. A third and final reason for questioning the wisdom of making de-personalisation a necessary and desirable consequence of the primacy of tradition is that it simply does not cohere with the main thrust of Eliot's essay to do so.

For Eliot's aim, kept steadily in view throughout, is to suggest how the truest individuality is nurtured by tradition, and only exists where tradition is revered and cherished. More strongly, where a work of art is fostered by the sense of tradition, it can be more than merely novel. It can shed a light powerful enough to modify subtly all the works of art which preceded it in the tradition, what Eliot calls « the order of the monuments ». Eliot's real enemy is not individuality, but a sentimental and anti-traditional version of what individuality involves. This seems clear from a remark to the effect that the greatness of a piece of writing does not flow from the greatness or supposed originality of the *emotions* which produced it, but from the « pressure » under which a fusion takes place of elements, meanings, drawn from tradition in the « now » of the poet's own place and time.

Theological bearings of Eliot's theory

Eliot himself believed that poetry could serve as an analogue of religion⁽¹⁰⁾. In both, he thought, truth is accessible through the medium of images. Here he drew on a line of reflection in English literature and theology going back in essen-

⁽¹⁰⁾ T. S. ELIOT, *The Use of Poetry and the Use of Criticism* (London 1964²), pp. 137 ff., where Eliot especially commends the Abbé Henri Brémond's *Prayer and Poetry* for its attempt to « establish the likeness, and the difference of kind and degree, between poetry and mysticism ».

tials to S. T. Coleridge⁽¹¹⁾. The unity and distinctiveness of this English contribution to theology has been affirmed by Hans Urs von Balthasar in his comments on the theological aesthetic of Hopkins in *Herrlichkeit*⁽¹²⁾, but its clearest statement is surely to be found in J. H. Newman's *Essay in Aid of a Grammar of Assent*. For Newman, although reason may penetrate the intelligible content of revelation and to some degree demonstrate its rationality, nevertheless, revelation in itself is primarily expressed in images which « rest » in the imagination⁽¹³⁾. In Eliot's *Four Quartets*, the analogue between divinity and poetry is all-pervasive, for the entry of the Uncreated Word into the finite realm is refracted in the words of the poet⁽¹⁴⁾. Insofar as theology is an exploration of revealed images it resembles the work of the poet and critic⁽¹⁵⁾.

There is nothing fantastic, therefore, in the suggestion that Eliot's account of poetic tradition may serve as an illuminating analogue for what Christians mean by tradition in the theological sense. More especially, Eliot's essay, once transposed into theological terms, indicates directions for theology that are peculiarly apt to the present day. To risk a simplification of an egregious kind, we can say that Western Christian theology and sensibility in the last hundred years has veered wildly between the two poles of individualism and authoritarianism, between the free, unfettered life of the enquiring spirit and appeal to authority, however conceived. It has never found that integration, balance and wholeness in the relation between the tradition and the individual talent which Eliot's essay evokes.

(11) See S. PRICKETT, *Romanticism and Religion. The Tradition of Coleridge and Wordsworth in the Victorian Church* (Cambridge 1976).

(12) H. U. VON BALTHASAR, *Herrlichkeit. Eine Theologische Ästhetik* (Einsiedeln 1961), II, 2, pp. 720-1.

(13) J. H. NEWMAN, *Essay in Aid of a Grammar of Assent* (London 1870; 1895), p. 119.

(14) See H. BLAMIRE, *Word Unheard: A Guide through Eliot's Four Quartets* (London 1969), *passim*.

(15) For an account of this in terms of verbal images, see A. FARRER, *The Glass of Vision* (London 1948), and in terms of visual images, A. NICHOLS, O.P., *The Art of God Incarnate: Theology and Image in Christian Tradition* (London 1980).

In Protestantism, the period of liberalism was replaced after the Great War of 1914-18 by the Neo-Orthodox revival, an exaltation of the authority of the Word of God in Karl Barth and his European disciples, an exaltation of the authority of the early Councils in Anglicanism. These in their turn have been replaced by a new liberalism which is more tired and more desperate than the old. In Catholicism, the epoch of Modernism, with its extreme stress on experience and religious feeling, was succeeded by an age of imposed theological constraint working through an unprecedentedly powerful Papacy, what Dr. Karl Rahner has called *der pianische Monolithismus*. The lid was, of course, removed at the Second Vatican Council, an attempt by the Papacy to partially repatriate decision-making in the Church to the episcopate with whom it had been very largely originally lodged. But the behaviour of the stored-up contents have made the theologian's chest look more like Pandora's Box than the cupboard of the Gospels from which the wise householder brought forth treasures both old and new. Needless to say, theological confusion breeds its own sicknesses, in missionary outreach, in pastoral care and finally in the intellectual life itself, which in no discipline can ever progress if it is continually obliged to re-make its own foundations.

Curiously enough, the plea Eliot made for a recovery of the sense of tradition has acquired its extraordinary relevance to Catholic theology just at a time when the theological idea of tradition, and the history of that idea, is better understood in scholarly terms by Christians than ever before. A large number of monographs on the notion of tradition in various writers and periods have been penned by historians of doctrine. A number of fine syntheses of this secondary material have also been produced, notably Père Yves Congar's *La Tradition et les traditions*, published between 1960 and 1963 and all the more notable for its author's influence as an accredited peritus on the Second Vatican Council then sitting⁽¹⁶⁾. A comparison of

⁽¹⁶⁾ Y. M.-J. CONGAR, O.P., *La Tradition et les traditions* (Paris 1960-3; E. t.: *Tradition and Traditions* (London 1966), to which reference is made in the following.

Congar's study with Eliot's essay is illuminating, and can indicate some criteria for a programme of theological reform.

Congar's theory of Christian tradition

After an exhaustive survey of references to the word « tradition » and its cognates in Scripture, the Fathers, the mediæval doctors and the writings of Catholic theologians from the Counter-Reformation to the nineteenth century Catholic revival, Congar plunges into what he calls « an analysis and synthesis of the idea of tradition »⁽¹⁷⁾. Etymologically, tradition must mean « the handing on of things received ». It implies then, as Eliot had affirmed, a receptive (« things received ») but also an active, indeed creative (« handing on »), attitude to the past. In the case of Christian tradition, however, this essential relationship with the past does not simply establish a corpus of human meanings, as with Eliot. More than this, it makes possible the transmission of a *doctrina salutaris*⁽¹⁸⁾, a teaching about divine salvation actually drawing us into the sphere of that salvation. The salvation in question Congar has already defined as a mutual relationship of knowledge and love between God and ourselves. Nevertheless, insofar as this *doctrina salutaris* is still *doctrina*, the analogy with a corpus of human meanings stands.

Congar further suggests that this transmission of a « covenant-relationship » in tradition takes up by grace a prior feature of the general human condition, namely inter-dependence or « la médiation fraternelle »⁽¹⁹⁾. We depend on each other at the natural level; in studying the idea of tradition we see that we also depend on each other at the supernatural level;

⁽¹⁷⁾ *Ib.*, pp. 237 ff.

⁽¹⁸⁾ *Ib.*, p. 239, with a glance at St Thomas' opening article in the *Summa Theologiae* which Congar explores further in « Traditio und Sacra Doctrina bei Thomas von Aquin », in *Kirche und Überlieferung* (Festgabe J. Geiselmann), Freiburg 1960, pp. 170-210.

⁽¹⁹⁾ Y. M.-J. CONGAR, *Tradition and Traditions*, *op. cit.*, pp. 240-1.

and in addition we can glimpse through this aspect of the divine Economy, something of the self-giving of the Triune God. This is well said, but surely « brotherly mediation » suggests an entirely *synchronic* process, whereas what Congar really needs at this point is a comparison with a *diachronic* process. More appropriate here, in fact, would be an appeal to something like Eliot's theory of poetic tradition which sees the literary culture of a society (a reality operative on all levels, from the most to the least sophisticated) as the taking up of individuals into a life-giving chain of succession in which the long-dead are immortal and become articulate in their successors here and now.

Congar, like Eliot, regards tradition as transformative of human interiority, not simply something situated in the exterior, public realm. For Eliot, incorporation into the public tradition means the re-casting of the interiority of the person so incorporated, in such a way that the bounds of merely individual perception, expression and interpretation are broken through. For Congar too:

the social and even the juridical structure of the transmission and acceptance of faith is a sort of sacrament of the most mystical and spiritual reality ⁽²⁰⁾.

And echoing the dialectic of « Tradition and the Individual Talent », Congar has it that the Christian life of faith is

something entirely personal and interior; quite definitely, however, this is not an individualising force, but one which incorporates; and it is something received, in which one joins and participates ⁽²¹⁾.

But whereas in the case of poetic tradition, the « force » or power concerned is the creativity of finite spirit, in the case of tradition theologically defined, Holy Tradition, it is the (Holy) Spirit of God himself who energises the entire process of transmission and incorporation ⁽²²⁾.

⁽²⁰⁾ *Ib.*, pp. 14-15.

⁽²¹⁾ *Ib.*, p. 243.

⁽²²⁾ *Ib.*, pp. 338-46.

Congar now turns to the section of his work which provides its title, the establishing of a distinction between « the traditions » and « tradition »⁽²³⁾. The « traditions » are the kind of thing discussed by the Council of Trent in its debate with the Reformers: aspects of Christian faith, the *regula fidei*, or the Christian life, *institutio christiana*, not contained formally in the canon of Scripture. Trent had in mind such things as the oral teaching of the apostles on the interpretation of the Old Testament, its christological and ecclesiological significance, and their equally oral worship, the sacraments as Liturgy, as language-in-action⁽²⁴⁾. It was these limited, though important, matters that post-Tridentine theology envisaged when it spoke of tradition as a separate *fons revelationis*, alongside and parallel to Scripture.

But these are not Congar's primary focus. He is concerned to shift our attention to a more comprehensive sense of tradition. This concern is explicable in terms of three factors. Firstly, historians of the Catholic Reformation had become (on the whole) dubious as to whether Trent really intended to canonise a « two source » view of tradition, not least because of the Council's rejection of a *partim... partim* formula which would have made such a dual source theory clear⁽²⁵⁾. Secondly, historians of doctrine had made it abundantly clear that a more holistic view of tradition was temporally prior⁽²⁶⁾. Thirdly, Congar's own theological penetration — and the breakthrough here is comparable to that of Eliot's essay — suggested to him

⁽²³⁾ *Ib.*, pp. 287-91.

⁽²⁴⁾ *Ib.*, pp. 156-69 where Congar follows particularly the studies of E. ORTIGUES, « Ecritures et Traditions apostoliques au concile de Trente », *Recherches de Science Religieuse* 36 (1949), and J. R. GEISELMANN, « Das Konzil von Trent über das Verhältnis der Heiligen Schrift und der nicht geschriebenen Traditionen », in M. SCHMAUS (ed.), *Die mündliche Überlieferung* (Munich 1957).

⁽²⁵⁾ How much should be « read into » this is still disputed; Congar comments, « Doubtless the Fathers of Trent did not see, in the option they took, what we see », *Tradition and Traditions*, *op. cit.*, p. 166.

⁽²⁶⁾ See e.g. G. TAVARD, *Holy Writ or Holy Church?* (London 1966), pp. 3-21.

that this temporal priority should be a theological priority as well.

Congar presents tradition, therefore, as the whole within which Christian life and reflection are situated. It is

the transmission of the whole Gospel, that is, the whole Christian mystery, in any form ⁽²⁷⁾.

The reiteration of « whole » here picks up the same emphasis in Eliot's picture of literary tradition as what I have called a « corpus » of meanings. The primary expression of tradition is Scripture itself, willed by God as the internal norm of the Church formed, sustained and extended by tradition. But the meaning of Scripture (compare for Eliot the meaning or referential range of any great text) is to be found only in connection with a whole host of other enactments or monuments (compare Eliot's « the order of monuments ») which make up the fabric of the Church's life. In a diversified but integrated whole, the Liturgy and the teaching of the Fathers, conciliar and papal definitions, and the witness of the ordinary Christian life, the Christian saints and Christian art all play their part in traditioning the Gospel ⁽²⁸⁾. Of this total process, the Holy Spirit is, as we have seen, the transcendent cause or Subject. Relying on a happier predecessor of Dr Hans Küng, Johann Adam Möhler, Congar concludes that the Spirit creates from within both the unity of tradition and also the expressions of its special genius ⁽²⁹⁾. The transcendent subjectivity of the Spirit enters our world through the corporate or inter-personal subjectivity of Christ's Church — which, as we have noted, should be characterised diachronically, not simply synchronically, and so along the lines of Eliot's essay.

⁽²⁷⁾ Y. M.-J. CONGAR, *Tradition and Traditions*, op. cit., pp. 14-15.

⁽²⁸⁾ *Ib.*, pp. 427-58.

⁽²⁹⁾ See *ib.*, pp. 193-6 for Congar's sympathetic reading of Möhler's *Die Einheit in der Kirche* (1825) and *Symbolik* (1832). The combination of admiration for Möhler and acceptance of Geiselman's thesis on Trent is not fortuitous: both were Tübingen theologians with the characteristic organic, holistic sense of Tradition learnt partly from German Romanticism.

It is by conformity with the Church's self-awareness and her memory of what she has received that any putative expression of the Christian faith must be judged authentically normative — or not. As Eliot says of the work of the poet, « Its fitting in is a test of its value », pointing out at the same time that the test can only « be slowly and cautiously applied » and requires sensitivity, respect, tact and patience⁽³⁰⁾. The English Benedictine Cardinal Aidan Gasquet is said to have remarked to Pope Leo XIII in a moment of abstractedness in defence of a colleague: « After all, Holiness, none of us is infallible ». Eliot certainly remarks of the coherence of a literary work with the tradition: « We are none of us infallible judges of conformity »⁽³¹⁾. The remarkable infrequency with which the Roman magisterium attempts such judgments in the contemporary Church is a model of the restraint desirable in this area.

Conclusions and proposals

If an Eliotic-Congarian theory of tradition is valid, then it follows that the first pre-requisite of the theologian is not originality so much as docility: an active, eager, lively willingness to be formed, instructed and inspired. The monuments of tradition are mediations of a prior and greater presence. Through them, the Word and Image of God is given words and images that he may speak and show himself⁽³²⁾. This in turn suggests some more particular criteria for theological writing:

Firstly, the epistemology of theology, its distinctive mode of understanding, can only be found within tradition, that is, within the historical communion of the Church. Theology can-

⁽³⁰⁾ T. S. ELIOT, *The Sacred Wood*, *op. cit.*, p. 57.

⁽³¹⁾ *Ib.*

⁽³²⁾ « Word and Image »: if a statement of the transcendent Subject of tradition requires a pneumatology, then surely a statement of its transcendent Object requires a Christology. The Father is alluded to, in an appropriately apophatic way, as Origin and Goal of these two economies.

not be written without, much less against, the society of the faithful⁽³³⁾.

Secondly, as Scripture is the primary expression of tradition, there can be no sound theology which is not rooted in Scripture and irradiated by it. Scripture in this sense is not primarily an ancient text as historically re-constructed, but the Church's book. This recalls the need to keep in perspective the significance attached to the findings of the methods of contemporary biblical exegesis. The meaning of Scripture is not simply to be found in its historical genesis, but also over time, within the order of the monuments that follow from it⁽³⁴⁾.

Thirdly, theology must be fed by all the Christian generations, each of which was open to God and whose voices, in the words of Eliot's *Little Gidding* are « tongued with fire beyond the language of the living ». Their teaching, literature and art should be seen as enabling, not disabling factors, in the theological quest. How is it that Küng's *On Being a Christian*, for all its merits, can formulate its account of Jesus by way of a deliberate overleaping of these generations, accompanied by unhappy metaphors of « peeling off layers of encrustation »?⁽³⁵⁾

Finally, theology must be informed by the witness of the mystics and the saints for it is in their lives and awareness that the transforming power of the Spirit of tradition is at its clearest and most palpable. Theology must regain the quality of being *scientia sanctorum* — because it is the saints who are the principal explorers of the mystery of God. We may then find that the best part of the theologian's work is that in which these ancestors of his « assert their immortality most vigorously ».

This programme amounts to a revolution as radical as Eliot's, the abandonment by the theological artist of his ro-

⁽³³⁾ For the notion of an « ecclesiological *a priori* » in theology, see C. ERNST, O.P., *Multiple Echo. Explorations in Theology* (London 1979), p. 139.

⁽³⁴⁾ It is the great merit of H. G. GADAMER's, *Truth and Method* (London 1975) to suggest how this can be so.

⁽³⁵⁾ H. KÜNG, *On Being a Christian* (New York 1976), pp. 126-33.

mantic status as a loner in the garret — nowadays all too well carpeted and furnished — of a latterday *quartier latin*, and his reinsertion into the tradition and common life of the *plebs sancta Dei*, the holy people of God throughout the ages. The individual talent must be the servant, not the master. In Hermann Hesse's *The Glass Bead Game* our age is criticised as the « Age of the Feuilleton », an age that « appears to have had only the dimmest notion of what to do with culture » and given over to an untrammelled individualism. For Hesse, the mental culture of our time, « squandering its strength in excessive vegetative growth » (one thinks of the extraordinary length of some recent Christological studies!), could only be brought back to its senses by « a new, monastically austere, intellectual discipline ». Through that renunciation, the vigour of the free personal spirit might be united with the universality of reason. Could not the same be achieved for theological reason? Should we not wish to echo Hesse and say:

We moderns, on the other hand, do not even speak of major personalities until we encounter men who have gone beyond all original and idiosyncratic qualities to achieve the greatest possible integration with the generality, the greatest possible service to the suprapersonal ⁽³⁶⁾.

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⁽³⁶⁾ H. HESSE, *The Glass Bead Game* (London 1970; Harmondsworth 1972), p. 16.